



The Living Fossils

A Two-Hander Play

By David Quang Pham

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

DR. **CUC** HOANG, 30/40s femme Vietnamese American, a biochemist specializing in endotoxins. She was born near Hai Phong, raised and studied in Chicago, and moved to New York City for work. Cuc was named after her mother's favorite national park.

HAI, a Mangrove horseshoe crab who was imported from Hai Phong.

/ME **HAI**, 30/40s femme Viet, mother last seen when Cuc was a kid.

/REPORTER, 30/40s, a television or radio reporter (prerecorded).

PROPS (3)

- Horseshoe Crab with a label that reads: "Hai Phong"
 - Cardboard/Paper Craft
 - Puppet (Playwright Pham has an 18" horseshoe crab plush)
- Cell Phone
- Syringe (fake)

NOTES

/ - interruptions or interjections

Playwright Pham has 4 lab coats

TECH

Scene 1 - Audio for radio news reports and phone call, projections are a bonus

Scene 3 - Audio of beach sounds and phone call, dawn lighting

SYNOPSIS

In *The Living Fossils*, Dr. Cuc Hoang is tasked with harvesting horseshoe crabs' blood for medicine when an epidemic ravages New York. But when a crab from her birthplace in Vietnam is imported to her lab, it is this motherly horseshoe crab that draws blood from this biochemist.

ACT I

SCENE 1

RED RIVER IN VIETNAM – UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO, EARLY 2020

In the shadows of the Red River, a mother-daughter pair of MANGROVE HORSESHOE CRABS swim together. A puppeteer maneuvers this 16-inch adult and her 4-inch baby.

Meanwhile, at UChicago, CUC HOANG – a biochemistry PhD student in her 30s – speaks with ME (pronounced: “meh”) on a horseshoe-shaped phone.

The puppeteer could be ME or the phone call could be pre-recorded.

CUC

Nuoc den (Vietnamese: “Dirty water”)?

ME (PHONE)

Dung. Nuoc den (Viet: “Yes. Dirty water”).

CUC

Nuoc (Viet: “Water”)– The water sure is dirty.

ME (PHONE)

Nuoc My ban thiu (Viet: “America is dirty”).

CUC

If America’s dirty, then why fly here?

ME (PHONE)

I can’t swim. That’s why I fly. And ya *tieng Viet* (Viet: “Vietnamese”) is dirty.

CUC

Dad no longer speaks it. He’s no help. I– I can’t help it.

ME (PHONE)

Only I can help ya. But ya two never visit.

CUC

When you see Lake Michigan for the first time, I’ll consider revisiting the Gulf of Tonkin.

ME (PHONE)

Vinh Bac Bo (Viet: “Gulf of Tonkin”). But, there’s this very special pond in *Haiphong*.

CUC

You could've shown me before dad took me away.

ME (PHONE)

A 9-year-old would not be ready to face my 10-foot friends.

The HORSESHOE CRABS flaunt their
10 legs.

CUC

10 feet? No one can grow that tall. And when did Vietnam start using imperial units?

ME (PHONE)

Yards, miles. We're 8,000 miles away.

CUC

My lab measures in metric like the rest of the world. No feet here.

ME (PHONE)

And no face. We see ya not for a long time.

CUC

You'll finally see who I've grown up to be.

ME (PHONE)

When ya introduce me to uh?

CUC

Introduce you to what? The Chicago Bean?

The HORSESHOE CRABS swim under a
manmade bean-shaped structure.

ME (PHONE)

Ya single for the rest of ya life?

CUC

Oh, come on. I work in teams!

ME (PHONE)

Not what I mean...

CUC

Finding someone is just not in my DNA. Besides, biochemistry is what anchors me.

ME (PHONE)

Just don't let what's *current* take ya away.

The HORSESHOE CRABS follow the
current into the unseen darkness.

CUC

2020 is- Ugh. Well, when you get here, it will
be just you and me. I won't bring up the world.

From the darkness where the
horseshoe crabs are hidden, the
things ME mentions bringing
(algae, mollusk shells, clams,
fishes, and crabs) are tossed out
into the open. These are what
horseshoe crabs eat.

ME (PHONE)

When I land here, I bring you the whole world.
I bring you algae. I bring you mollusk shells.
I bring you clams. I bring you fishes, CRABS!
I bring you everything but...

CUC & ME (PHONE)

...peace. (Laugh)

CUC

Never change, mom.

ME (PHONE)

I need to- (resonant cough).

ME coughs. Anchor drops. The phone
hangs up. Beep beep beep beep...

Lights on in the darkness. An
anchor has crushed the MOTHER
HORSESHOE CRAB. The BABY tries
desperately to save her.

CUC

Me (Viet: "Mom")...

CUC abruptly storms out.

A dim spotlight stays on the BABY
MANGROVE HORSESHOE CRAB.

COVID-related news reports are
audible. Fast forward to 2028.

ANCHOR (RADIO)

Our nation's 2028 E. coli outbreak now ravages
the Big Apple. The case was first reported in
Paw Paw, Michigan from the recalled *Monkey
Smacks* sold in January and February. Despite
the ongoing protests against another recent
spurs of government deregulations, the plant in
Battle Creek is ramping up production.

ANCHOR (RADIO)

The public has no confidence in pharmaceutical companies to keep this national health crisis under control as they've cut corners for their bottom line. To make matters worse, bacterial endotoxin tests are in short supply leading to compromised medical equipment, drugs, and biological products. We go live to Dr. Cuc Hoang and her team of researchers as they issue a press release in light of these developments.

The 4" BABY HORSESHOE CRAB grows
into a 16" ADULT HORSESHOE CRAB.

CUC (RADIO)

We cannot make light of the situation. At the start of the last pandemic 8 YEARS AGO, our programs cut corners to grant many of our PhDs. And just like that, we'll face this epidemic together. To be transparent, our team of researchers have poured our blood, sweat, and tears... But mostly blood from countless limulus polyphemus's. The International Union for Conservation of Nature has now categorized these Atlantic horseshoe crabs as endangered species. For the time being, it is not in our jurisdiction to process any more lysate for LAL testing. But, I ask the public to not worry. There are Pacific imports awaiting us. We will move the / needle

A net-like shadow looms over the
grown HORSESHOE CRAB. Someone
steals her away.

SCENE 2

ANIMAL HOUSE FACILITY IN A BIOMEDICAL LAB, MARCH 2028

A MANGROVE HORSESHOE CRAB is on
display. They go by HAI. The
horseshoe crab is barely an adult
and acts as though they are.

CUC enters. She looks at the
clipboard and reads.

CUC

Haiphong, Vietnam. Estimated birth: 2020. [Me...](#)

CUC does not draw blood.

Four days pass.

CUC finally decides to draw blood.
She grabs a syringe.

HAI

Mau ban (Viet: "Dirty blood")!

CUC falls back and accidentally
stabs herself with the syringe.
She puts herself in the corner.

CUC

Dirty blood?!

HAI

Nuoc den (Viet: "Dirty water").

CUC

Bloody hell, you actually speak.

HAI

I'm surprised I can as you've dehydrated me.

CUC

Horseshoe crabs can only survive four days out
of water.

HAI

What day is this?

CUC

Day five.

HAI

Five?!

CUC

I'll get you water!

HAI

When I do, I'm gonna claw your eyes out with my
ten legs!

CUC

Don't test the water. Now, tell me how are you
doing that?

HAI

Well, I just take my ten legs and dig them into
your eye sockets.

CUC

No... How are you speaking without a mouth?

HAI

I assume we both have brains.

CUC

Yours hasn't evolved.

HAI

Excuse me?

CUC

It's not a bad thing. Actually. Homo homo sapiens have de-evolved.

HAI

You troglodytes are so hard on yourself.

CUC

Take it easy with the insults, trilobite.

HAI

Bite me.

CUC

I'm vegan.

HAI

I guess humans have really de-evolved.

CUC

We're more than eating animals.

HAI

So vegans eat plankton.

CUC

I'm not pescatarian.

HAI

Then why does it smell like death here?

CUC

You don't have a nose either.

HAI

You look like death.

CUC

It's all part of the job.

HAI

What's a job?

CUC

Things you do to make money to trade to live.

HAI

Well, I'm proud of your um... imagination. I,
on the other leg, work for my food. No middle
man or middle crab.

CUC

You eat the nastiest things.

HAI

When I was home, I ate the whole world. I ate
the algae. I ate the mollusk shells. I ate the
clams. I ate the fishes, CRABS! I ate
everything but...

CUC

(Remembering)

Please, stop-

CUC forces her hand on HAI.

"THE LIVING (LEITMOTIF)"

CUC is transported to that special
pond her mother took her as a kid
in Haiphong, briefly. She lets go.

END OF "THE LIVING (LEITMOTIF)"

HAI

You're that crazy human.

The syringe is still stuck in CUC.
She is dizzy.

CUC

(Breathing heavily)

Crazy is an understatement.

HAI

No, no, you look like her.

CUC

I look like any other Viet?

HAI

You're special here in this bright cave,
troglodyte.

CUC

It's a lab, trilobite.

HAI

The other creatures in the lab.

CUC

My subordinates.

HAI

They don't like you.

CUC

Of course. I'm their boss. No one likes their boss.

HAI

You're not a predator. You're a prey / just like me.

CUC

/ Pray you don't get in my way from / saving

HAI

/ Ya can't save yourself. Ya hurt. Aww... Ya got a boo / boo

CUC

/ Don't speak to me like a child- Wait... you / talk?

HAI

/ Dat needle seems to not belong in ya appendages.

She painfully pulls it out.

CUC

Worry not for my skin is a hard shell.

HAI

Ya speaking my language.

CUC

I wished I spoke Viet more than I have- Wait- Am I tripping?

HAI

Nah, *I'm the one who's trippin'*: Hanoi to Taipei to Seattle, now New York.

CUC

I'm *talking* here. How are you even doing this?!
(Motioning towards her own moving mouth)
You got no teeth. Not even a jaw.

HAI

Welp, ya made in my image. Ya jaw dropping.

CUC defensively aims the syringe.

CUC

You ain't my kind. Let's not get off on the wrong foot.

HAI

It's rather hard to pick da right foot when ya got ten of dem!

CUC

Horseshoe! You've got ten seconds to explain yourself. *Mot... Hai...* (Viet: "One... Two...")

HAI

Dat's where I spawned!

CUC reads the clipboard then stows away the syringe.

CUC

Hai...? Haiphong?

HAI

Be careful where ya put dat needle. It's sharp.

CUC

You're not my mother.

HAI

Ya sure as sharp as a troglodyte.

CUC

Wannabe trilobite!

HAI

Bite me.

CUC

I'm vegan.

HAI

So, you eat plankton?

CUC

That's pescetarian. You're not worth eating.

HAI

Pesky. Why not? My digestive tracts contain the whole world. It has algae. It has mollusk shells. It has clams. It has fishes, CRABS! It has everything.

CUC

But peace...

HAI

What brings ya peace?

CUC

Not this city that's for sure.

HAI

Do ya have a pond ya like to swim in?

CUC

Nuoc den (Vietnamese: "Dirty water").

HAI

Dirty. My kind of water.

CUC

How often does one of my kind set foot in your waters?

HAI

Not often. But my community has a legend of this crazy person who kept laying her appendages on my fellow "trilobites."

CUC

Where is she?

HAI

I don't know. She left before I hatched.

CUC

(Reading the clipboard)

Born in 2020? Mom...

HAI

Speaking of- I needa return to my motherland.

CUC

Not without your blood.

HAI

Ew. Ya speaking like a shark.

CUC

I'm vegan.

HAI

Whale sharks eat plankton.

CUC

Your bloods not to drink.

HAI

Are ya gonna wear me like a hat like dem sea mammals?

CUC

(Laughing like a dolphin)

Ha ha. These drugs, I may as well be a dolphin.

CUC

Where is this pond?

HAI

Haiphong.

CUC

I know that. Where in Haiphong.

HAI

In the dirtiest area.

CUC

That narrows nothing.

HAI

A creek from the Red River will lead to that special pond. If you take me back, I'll lead the way.

CUC

No way. We need your blood first.

HAI

Mind your own blood.

CUC

Your blue blood is our goldmine in medicine!

HAI

Well, I can't show ya where to go if I'm dead.

CUC

You won't die.

HAI

Can ya say the same for the horseshoe crabs that came before?

CUC

They-

HAI

I smell their sacrifice. The stench of it.

CUC

You have no nose.

HAI

I've got eyes. Ya need to clean those blue blood stains.

CUC

Many didn't make it on initial samplings. But, this lab has improved our methodology. These early Atlantic horseshoe crabs were unfortunate.

HAI

Ohhh. *They're Atlantic*. Why didn't you say so? Atlantic sea life don't matter.

CUC

Does that mean I can-

HAI

If you want to spill blood, spill mine at home.

CUC

Your home...

HAI

Yours. Cuc.

CUC

My home is here.

HAI

Troglodytes started in a dark cave and now live in a light cave.

CUC

I don't live in a lab.

HAI

Ya fellow lab-dwellers don't seem to like ya.

CUC

My team? There's no bad blood amongst us.

HAI

I got word they're gonna feed ya to the sharks.

CUC

It's an idiom.

HAI

Idiot. Ya just like me. A prey.

CUC

I'm no prey.

HAI

Is there an idiom for stupid vegans?

CUC

I'm reconsidering my diet.

HAI

And so is ya ecosystem.

CUC

If this lab wants to replace me, they better replace the mobile health vehicle first.

CUC drags away HAI.

CUC

We're getting outta here.

HAI

Ya sure out for blood!

The lab transforms into a car.

SCENE 3

VEHICLE DRIVING OUT THE CITY, DAY, MARCH 2028

CUC sets HAI in the passenger seat. CUC drives.

HAI

Ahhhh!!! We've been eaten by a crocodile!

CUC

Relax... We're inside a car.

HAI

Where is acar taking us?

CUC

The Pacific to be specific.

HAI

Are we there yet?

CUC

It's going to take several days.

HAI

Will ya let in some nature sounds?

CUC

Mother Earth's Plantasia by Mort Garson?

CUC plays the Bluetooth.

HAI

That's out of this world.

CUC

Seems the one thing we share is musical tastes.

HAI

Ya vegans have horrible tastes. This music
shouldn't be in this world.

CUC switches songs. David Quang
Pham will write a short punk song
that repeats "I hate you."

HAI

(Disapprovingly)

What is dat?!

CUC

Spotify?

HAI

What animal genus is dat?

CUC

It's an app.

HAI

Appetizer. Ah, a prey I see...

CUC

What do you have against punk?

HAI

Whoever wrote this has no ears.

CUC

This artist is apparently Vietnamese American.

HAI

(Motherly)

Ya keep listening to dat, ya will get tattoos,
then join a gang, and it'll be da end of it.

CUC

What could your gang possibly listen to?

HAI

I know my Viet. Give me Nguyen Thien Dao.

CUC types on her shell phone and searches up the Vietnamese-French contemporary classical composer and shows the screen to HAI.

HAI

One of his chamber pieces will do.

CUC

Dad told me this was my mom's favorite piece. And yes, my dad showed me a cheo dance moves after criticizing *Paris by Night* for being so commercial, ugh.

HAI

How is ya dad?

CUC

You can never know with him. He's one in a billion.

HAI

I once was one in a billion. Now, I'm lucky to be one in a thousand.

CUC

Right... Well, the IUCN Species Survival Commission can only work with what they have.

HAI

I-U-C-N?

CUC

The International Union for Conservation of Nature.

HAI

Da world wants to help me?

CUC

That's an overstatement. Everyone but America wants to help you.

HAI

Dat's what ya dad's been surrounding himself with... Was his American ideals osmosis to ya?

CUC

It was more osmoregulation...

HAI

Dat's some salmon shit ya talking about.

CUC

Being able to modify the function of your gills to pump out sodium ions to counteract the less saline freshwater is... uh... *smolt-ing* hot.

HAI

So, which one is da fresh and which one is da salt?

CUC

Fresh or salt?

HAI

Haiphong or Chicago?

CUC

It's not an instinct of mine to answer everything you ask.

HAI

It makes sense dat you spawned in Vietnamese freshwater before spending most of ya life on da salty American soil.

They drive by the scenery of the Great Lakes.

HAI

Nuoc co nguon (Viet: "Water has a source.")

(Repeating)

Nhu cay co goc, nhu / nuoc co nguon (Viet: "A tree has roots much like water has a source").

CUC

As you can see, the Great Lakes...

HAI

Tell acar to stop.

CUC

No chance you leave my sight.

HAI

I'm not gonna leave ya again.

CUC

Again?

HAI

Pinky tail promise?

CUC

Pinky tail promise...

CUC wraps her pinky around HAI's tail.

They stop by the Great Lakes.

SCENE 4

THE GREAT LAKES SHORE, DAY, MARCH 2028

The waves beat the shore.

CUC carries HAI out of their vehicle.

HAI

Can ya put me down? I ain't no cat, ya know?

CUC

And let you burrow yourself into the ground.
You take me for a fool.

HAI

Ain't all homo sapiens? But, a pinky tail
promise is a pinky tail promise.

CUC places HAI on the ground.

HAI

Ew...

CUC

That's probably what my mom would say.

HAI

She hasn't seen this?

CUC

It's not much different from the Pacific.

HAI

She lives in the Pacific.

CUC

Did.

HAI

Where is she now?

CUC

Not here. She almost was here.

HAI

I'm here.

CUC

No, you're not. Mom is not.

Digging is audible.

CUC reaches for HAI.

CUC

You little shit!

HAI

Relax. I'm just stretching! Dis sand is rough
for a Southeast Asian horseshoe crab.

CUC wipes out the syringe.

CUC

With the sand being rough, you shouldn't have a
problem with a little needle.

HAI

If ya gonna do me like dat, can I also draw
blood from ya?

CUC

Draw from my hallucinations as long as it
lasts, buddy.

HAI

It seems indefinite. Dat drug in dat syringe is
strong.

CUC

A dose is enough to put an infant orca to
sleep.

HAI

Ya should lay down... Be a beached killer whale
dat ya are!

CUC

Don't call me a whale, you giant sea cockroach!

HAI

Dis giant sea cockroach gets enough sleep. How
else are we still functioning and around?

CUC

I don't function by burying my head in the
sand. The public has done that over and over.
And now look at where they are. Heading towards
impending doom, epidemic after pandemic.

HAI

I don't know who *public* is, but I say... *Fuck the public.*

CUC

They pay me money...

HAI

I still don't know what *money* is... How about dis: I'll pay ya comfort and protection. Dat's tangible.

CUC

You have a hard shell.

HAI

It's not a hard sell to just... be free to bury ya head in da sand for a change.

CUC pockets the syringe and lays down on the ground. She closes her eyes.

HAI now embodies Cuc's mother, [ME HAI](#).

[ME HAI](#)

Cuc vang cua toi (Viet: "My golden nugget").

CUC

(Correcting [ME HAI](#))

Cuc Hoang...

[ME HAI](#)

Child. Don't correct me. Who else knows ya name better than ya own mother? I'll be taking back da golden nugget.

[ME HAI](#) extends a hand to CUC, but CUC rejects it. Instead, CUC stands and walks with [ME HAI](#) by her side.

[ME HAI](#)

Keep da compliment... Two feet is so much better than ten. But I still got off da wrong foot... Anywho, my other complement: I've been meaning to ask about ya father...

CUC

Alive and well.

ME HAI

Surprising since he's always overworked himself nearly to death. I'm guessing you've been taking a lot from him.

CUC

He's been there my whole life...

ME HAI

Da American life you've evolved into.

CUC

Evolved?

ME HAI

Yes, and it's nothing to be ashamed of. But losing ya voice. Ya culture. Shame is an understatement.

CUC

I don't understand most of what your side of the family has to say. That horseshoe crab... It's the first time I've spoken this much Viet since I held your hands.

ME HAI

Communication is like an appendix.

CUC

Useless organ. WAIT. When is the appendicitis coming?

ME HAI

Burst da bubble when you're ready.

CUC wipes out the syringe and aims it at ME HAI.

CUC

How could you let your life remain unchanged for generations while the world evolved?

ME HAI

It's in my blood.

CUC

And now your body wasn't prepared for a worldwide pandemic.

ME HAI

What's dat weird hermit crab-looking animal dat swims?

CUC

A nautilus?

ME HAI

Plural?

CUC

Nautili?

ME HAI

We can't all be nautili and swim away from danger.

ME HAI sways and moves about like a nautilus. She plants herself and moves like a horseshoe crab.

ME HAI

I'm a horseshoe crab. We are born grounded, and so we will die grounded.

CUC moves about.

CUC

Perhaps, I can be a vagabond nautilus sometimes.

ME HAI

You're a mudskipper. Ya can breathe air and water. Ya can climb trees.

CUC

I'm a biochemist, not a zoologist. You can't relate to me.

ME HAI

But... But all animals relate to one another. All life is related to an ancestor, to a common blood.

CUC

And you decide to be a missing piece in my ancestry.

ME HAI

I'm da ancestor dat only you'll know. But you're on ya way to being da ancestor dat all will remember. I'm da ancestor whose roots are too far and too lost in da mud, but yours will collect da forgotten waters. *Nhu cay co goc, nhu nuoc co nguon* (Viet: "A tree has roots much like water has a source").

CUC drops the syringe.

ME HAI

Ya father didn't raise you to litter!

CUC

Mom... I'm having an epiphany.

ME HAI

Well, have dat epiphany by a dumpster.

CUC

(Mumbling)

Do I or do I not want to have a mom...?

ME HAI picks up the syringe. She finally holds CUC's hands.

CUC

I wish dad didn't dump you...

ME HAI

It was either his daughter or his wife. Imports are costly and he could only afford da freshest of our bloodline.

CUC

I wanted the chance to see you again.

ME HAI

Well, here I am.

CUC

Not by the cold Atlantic but by the warm Pacific.

ME HAI

For countless families, 2020 was da most awful of times. But ya vision of da future should not be clouded by bad blood, slaughtering these poor defenseless creatures.

CUC

I would drain the life out of every single horseshoe crab in the world if it meant being with you one last time...

ME HAI

How many lives do horseshoe crabs have?

CUC

Is that a philosophical question?

ME HAI

How many legs do horseshoe crabs have?

CUC

Ten.

ME HAI

Now, how many hands?

CUC

They're not hands but claws and five sets of them.

ME HAI

I'm grateful dat dad raised a sharp-as-claws kid. But, da point is dat horseshoe crabs have no hands to write.

CUC

Why would they need to write? They don't.

ME HAI

But dey need ancestors. Everyone does. Dey need to remember dis and da only way dey have known since da beginning of time is through their blood.

CUC

But the / endotoxins...

ME HAI

/ End ya own toxins.

ME HAI takes the syringe and plants the needle in her chest.

ME HAI

Hold my blood forever in ya heart for my cells are warriors with hard shells to protect ya against all toxins. And ya four thousand descendants will thank ya for your cells, Dr. Cuc Hoang. I will always be here to give you a leg up. At least ten legs up, *cuc vang cua toi* (Viet: "my golden nugget").

ME HAI hands the syringe to CUC and returns to being the horseshoe crab HAI.

HAI

How does it feel to have blood drawn from ya, biochemist?

CUC

Hai... It feels like a fresh harvest...

CUC passes out. Her cell phone rings. She awakens. She looks at the silent horseshoe crab.

CUC

The hallucinations... It's worn out!

CUC swiftly answers her phone.

CUC

(On the phone)

I'd like to address the nation! Oh... Morning, Anton... I'm not currently at the lab. I'm just... taking a walk on the beach. Yes, I am well aware that it's February. You've got that right. This is an optimal season for Midwesterners. Huh? Missing? The mangrove horseshoe crab...? *It does not matter.*

HAI disapprovingly shakes. She bittersweetly looks upon HAI.

CUC

(On the phone)

She does not matter. Well, Anton, thank you for being the greatest assistant a biochemist could ever work with. You're getting a promotion first thing upon my return. Yes. Listen: I'd like to use my PTO now. I'm going to Haiphong in Vietnam! I need to take a very special friend home...

CUC hangs up her phone. She plays the woodwind and zither movement from "*Hon Thieng Song Nui*" (Viet: "*Sacred Soul of Rivers and Mountains*") by Nguyen Thien Dao. She picks up HAI.

CUC

Ban thuoc ve toi (Viet: "*You belong to me*").

Blackout.